

THE INDIAN OCEAN

MALDIVES

Capital city: Male
Area: 116 sq miles (300 sq km)
Population: 318,000
Official language: Dhivehi
Major religion: Muslim 100%
Government: Non-party democracy
Currency: Rufiyaa

COMOROS

Capital city: Moroni
Area: 838 sq miles (2,170 sq km)
Population: 768,000
Official languages: Arabic, French, Comoran
Major religions: Muslim 98%, other 2%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Comoros franc

MAURITIUS

Capital city: Port Louis
Area: 788 sq miles (2,400 sq km)
Population: 1,200,000
Official language: English
Major religions: Hindu 52%, Christian 28%, Muslim 17%, other 3%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Mauritian rupee

MADAGASCAR

Capital city: Antananarivo
Area: 226,656 sq miles (587,040 sq km)
Population: 17,400,000
Official languages: Malagasy and French
Major religions: Christian 41%, traditional beliefs 52%, Muslim 7%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Ariary

SEYCHELLES

Capital city: Victoria
Area: 176 sq miles (455 sq km)
Population: 80,469
Official languages: French Creole, English, French
Major religions: Christian 98%, other 2%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Seychelles rupee

The dried salt is stored in baskets. Workers then carry the heavy baskets on their heads to a waiting truck.

THE THIRD LARGEST of the world's oceans, the Indian Ocean covers 28 million sq miles (73 million sq km) and contains some 5,000 islands, many of them surrounded by coral reefs. This ocean is unique because, unlike the Atlantic and Pacific, it has no outlet to the north. It contains both the saltiest sea (the Red Sea), and the warmest sea (the Persian Gulf) on Earth. The Indian Ocean is at risk from pollution, especially from oil tankers leaving the Persian Gulf. Monsoon rains and tropical storms can bring disastrous flooding to its northern coasts.

CORAL ISLANDS

Coral is formed in warm waters by tiny creatures known as polyps. These marine creatures build limestone skeletons around themselves. Over many thousands of years, these skeletons gradually grow up toward the surface of the ocean to form a coral island. An atoll, shown right, is a form of circular coral reef that grows around an underwater volcano. As the volcano sinks, the coral forms an atoll. The water in the center is called a lagoon.



1. Corals grow in shallow waters around volcanic island.



2. Coral reef builds up as movements in the Earth's surface make the island sink.



3. Island finally disappears, leaving a coral atoll.



This port in Fremantle, Australia, handles freight from across the world.

SHIPPING ROUTES

More than 200 large ships a day sail around the Cape of Good Hope at the southern tip of Africa as they enter or leave the Indian Ocean. Many are vast tankers laden with oil from the Persian Gulf. Smaller ships are able to pass through the Suez Canal. On the other side of the Indian Ocean, ships pass through the Strait of Malacca carrying cargo to ports in eastern Asia.



ISLAND PARADISE

The islands of the Indian Ocean include coral atolls, like the Maldives and Seychelles, that attract thousands of tourists every year. Although this brings money to the islands, it also threatens to damage the environment. Gradual erosion of the coral reefs also leaves the islands exposed to ocean tides and flooding. This Maldivian island has a barrier to protect it from sea damage.



MADAGASCAR

Madagascar lies off the east coast of Africa and, because of its isolation, is home to many unique plants and animals. Most people in Madagascar scratch out a living by farming, clearing a new patch of land each year to plant their crops. One of the island's main crops is vanilla, grown for use as flavoring in food and drinks. Women traditionally have elaborate hairstyles that indicate the village they are from.

THE SALTY SEA

Oceans are salty because minerals dissolved from rocks by rivers are washed into them. Around the shores of the Indian Ocean, people extract the salt by channeling water into shallow pans. The Sun's heat evaporates the water, leaving salt behind, as shown here in Mauritius.